

VAN HOUTEN'S GHOST STORIES

by Kai Jas. Brennan

SYNOPSIS: This anthology of legends consists of historical and modern ghost stories relating to the town of Van Houten in Colfax County, New Mexico. Many of these stories come from the counselor staff of the NRA Whittington Center Adventure Camp, though some are older. This interesting cultural collection is intended for an amusing read, or to help with ideas for ghost stories to tell at Camp-out.

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Chapter 1

The Lights of Van Houten

This legend is one of the oldest known ghost stories from the town of Van Houten, estimated to be more than 20 years old at minimum. It is the local version of Dwaallichtjes or Will o' the Wisps.

The phenomenon is the light from a miner's carbide lantern which is seen walking away from the mine, as if going home from work. Travelers or other miners follow it, mistaking it for a person. It leads them into a remote area before extinguishing, leaving them completely stranded. Reports have also claimed of seeing a multitude of them walking in a line higher up in the hills, particularly around the external tramways of Mine 5 or in the hills in Mule Canyon.

Interestingly, this apparition could be related to geothermal activity, underground coal fires in the area, or the lost picnic location of the Devil's Kitchen, due to the eternal flames and gas emissions in these areas.

Chapter 2

Train Whistles & Other Sounds

Many who venture into Van Houten at night report odd sounds associated with the town's life or mining operations. Among these, the sound of a train horn is particularly well documented, primarily at night.

Additionally, some report hearing the sound of coal hitting the bottom of a minecart, with a dull metallic thud. Beyond these, some have heard music coming from the place where the clubhouse used to stand.

Sometimes, these sounds are associated with seeing lights in the valley, or seeing the town as if the buildings had never been demolished.

Chapter 3

Coors Related Legends

Even though it may not appear to be so, the Coors building is well within the limits of Van Houten. The hill behind the targets is Ghost Hill, so named for the children of Van Houten who would play upon its sides while their parents would picnic at the nearby Devil's Kitchen. Devil's Kitchen is on the other side of the Coors range, about 1000 feet away.

Ghost hill has a particularly infamous reputation with the counselors, for they claim that any night expeditions on the hill are certain to encounter the ghosts of the schoolchildren.

Additionally, the building at Coors where archery is held during Adventure Camp has its fair share of ghost stories. Generally speaking, many sources report hearing noises, among other things. Two stories of note will be expanded upon below.

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Two counselors, having arrived early to Adventure Camp by one day, decided to sleep in Coors for fun and to avoid paying a fee for a campsite or cabin for the night.

Evening was falling when they thought it was safe to drive up without the risk of someone coming across them by accident. The archery side of Coors had the door unlocked, and they went in. They had driven up there, and there were no vehicles or signs of people in the area. However, on the tables there was paperwork, a walkie talkie, and a fresh drink. It looked like someone had just left the building for a minute, and was imminently bound to return.

They planned to leave and come back later to avoid running into an unexpected visitor, and were walking to the other side to go out the door near the stage. From behind them, they heard the sound of footsteps outside the door where they had entered, and the sound of the doorknob turning. Fearing that they would be caught they took off running without a word (for they both heard the same thing and knew what it was) and tore out the other door.

Upon a cautious lap around the building, they found that there was still nobody in the area. No cars or people had arrived and the original door was still well sealed.

They left the area to return later. They ended up sleeping in the leadership classroom, and one of them slept poorly while the other reported sleeping well.

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Upon request, four counselors made a night trip to Coors to retrieve some materials for camp. They entered through the side door and immediately were uneasy. As they proceeded through the building looking for the materials they began to hear a banging on metal from in front of them

followed by a shuffling on the cement floor.

They shined all of their lights and covered the area to find the source, but as soon as they focused all their attention and saw nothing, they heard the same phenomenon from behind them but closer.

This event of looking one way and then hearing the same thing behind, but closer, continued just until it sounded like the things were upon them, and they exited without determining the origin of the sound.

Chapter 4

Following Music



Antiqued photo of the bushcraft structure.

A group of two counselors was building a small bushcraft structure on the hill behind the cabins, using an ax to cut down two pine trees for the construction. Every chop made a clamor, and they were stressed, thinking they could be caught. As they began to chop down the second tree, they

heard music coming towards them.

Believing that it was a counselor or other staff member coming to investigate the loud chopping sounds, and fearing retribution, they took off at a full sprint up the hill. It was already close and loud.

They ran as far and as fast as they could, until they collapsed from exhaustion. They looked back to see if they lost their pursuer. Only, the music was closer than before. The 200-300 foot uphill sprint had done nothing.

The music was directly upon them, and it wasn't normal at all. It was an old country song, from the 1930s-1940s (in the line of Tex Ritter or someone similar). Strangely, the only counselors who liked that kind of music had retired the year before.

They still thought it might be staff coming to investigate, so they continued their run uphill. The music kept growing closer, as if it were right on top of them, just until they reached the crest of the hill when it immediately stopped. During this run, there was no sign of people, and whatever was following them made no walking noise in the twigs and pine needles, only the music.

The two counselors proceeded back to the cabins via Mule Canyon, upon which they checked for cars. Everyone was in town, and there were no cars parked in the area. Later, they inquired if anyone had been in the area with music, which was met with a resounding no.

Chapter 5

The Tommyknocker



Watercolor as imagined by Delaney Nelson, 2025.

During an exploration of the interior of Mine 4 & 6, a group of explorers began hearing a hammering sound. For speculation, they attempted to recreate the sounds, dropping coal on coal, dropping coal on a railroad spike, and then hitting two railroad spikes together. Of these, it was most similar to the railroad spikes striking each other. They described the sound like a hammer on an anvil, or metal utensils in a pan. Three of the

four explorers claimed to hear these sounds.

It is important to note that these particular explorers had a history of leaving trash in the mine and removing artifacts from the shafts, with a prolific rap sheet.

During the imitation of these noises, they continued hearing the noises coming from in front of them. They decided to investigate and went after it. As they scrambled over the coal heaps, they heard the sound coming from behind them. They became convinced that they were being lured somewhere, so they decided to exit the mine.

They began to leave the room to get back to the main drift that led to the exit. They had made it back near the abandoned mine-cart when one of them turned around and saw the reflection of amber eyes in the corridor in the glow of their dim head-lamp.

They rushed to the main entrance. Nearing the brick wall, one of them turned around. He saw, very briefly, a forehead and eyes appear to peek up from behind the rubble, before vanishing again. It was a white forehead with a tuft of brown hair and golden eyes that absorbed light. In his words, it was like "when you're playing hide and seek with a little kid, and they peek up to see where you are before ducking down again." This terrified him and they expedited their exit.

As they were climbing over the gate (the last obstacle before getting out of the mine), the person who had seen the Tommyknocker second was overcome by a premonition. He understood that the Tommyknocker was waiting right behind the brick wall, and would take the opportunity to jump the wall and attack him as soon as he turned his back to climb the gate. Only once

his fellow explorers were outside and had him covered could he climb over to freedom.

This group has been planning to appease the Tommyknocker in the traditional manner by throwing pastries into the mine. Additionally, this group has refused to ever go into mines 4/6 again, due to their belief that the Tommyknocker was either warning them of imminent collapse or was intending to collapse the mine on them.

Chapter 6

The Dark Figure

This is a particularly interesting, well-repeated legend with numerous specific sightings. The stories are organized on a timeline, but there may well be more that are unrecorded.

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A group of counselors and instructors drove up to the gated entry of Mine 4 in Van Houten and got out of their car to look at the area. They were walking around in the bay near the table, talking about going on a night hike or looking for mountain lions.

In any case, they were standing around the car when they heard a tapping on the back of the truck's window from the outside. When they all turned to see what it was, there was a tall black figure, about 6-7 feet tall, fully opaque and pitch-black except for a white smile.

The figure was viewed by multiple parties from various angles. After the sighting, I am not sure what happened, for this story is well older than I, and I have only heard the climax from relaters.

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Two counselors were walking behind the cabins in the summer of 2023, when they saw the black figure standing at one of the telephone poles over the drainage ditch, about 50-100 feet away. They were immediately fearful and they felt a great pressure within their heads and immediately started shaking. They shone their lights on the figure, and it ran sideways along the treeline, far faster than a human could run. The figure never wavered, and it was plain to them that it was a large, tall figure running through the grass. They went into the nearest cabin where all the others were hanging out, and many witnesses that night remarked about how their faces looked like they'd seen a ghost (for in their minds, they had). After they told the story, some people went out to the same area to look for it, but it didn't make a reappearance that night.

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Later in the 2023 session, a group of four counselors went out to try to find the black figure. They drove up to the mine 4 gated entrance, and sat in silence facing away from the mine with the windows down, to wait and see if it would make an appearance.

Having been skunked for multiple previous 'hunts', they were not expecting anything. After a while, however, the boy in the back right seat said he felt pressure in his head, which so frequently precedes a sighting of this black figure. Progressively, the driver also started to feel the distinctive headache. After a while, all of the people in the truck no longer could muster the courage to look behind them towards the portal into the mine. It was as if they felt instinctively there was something there that they didn't want to see. They talked about this briefly and one of

them even commented that they felt it was in the truck bed. Soon after all of them had the pressure in their heads, which came and went for the rest of the story.

As they were sitting up at the mine, they were about next to the gate which is closed to prevent access to the service road leading to staff rock. They had positioned the car so that they were pointing away from the mine for a quick getaway.

After a while, the boy in the back left seat looked out the window on his side, and standing behind the gate was the black figure, about 7 feet away. It was as tall as previous accounts had said, and so purely black that it took out a chunk of the stars in the sky.

Upon seeing this, he made an exclamation, and the boy in the back right seat turned and also saw. Then the figure disappeared. At that point the boy in the back right seat reported that his head was in such a bad state that he would be physically sick, and the people in the front seats (who hadn't seen it with their own eyes) were getting more afraid, so they decided to make their getaway.

They turned on the car. The headlights flickered on, illuminating the road and the pine trees in front of them. Standing on the side of the road 20 feet before them was the black figure. All four of them immediately saw it and cried out, not needing to tell the others what they saw, for it was so plainly there. In their escape from Van Houten, they felt like they were being pursued, and the car hardly held on to the gravel as they drifted around corners.

Later, the counselor in the front passenger seat recanted having seen

it definitively and suggested that it was a shadow of the guardrail on the side of the road. Experiments were made to recreate the sighting, but no similar shadows could be produced. Additionally, the fact remains that in the moment, this counselor had no doubt in his mind what everyone was looking at, and saw it himself.

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One night, two counselors were arguing or otherwise having a heated discussion in one of the girls cabins back rooms. At the point where it came to a head, one of the counselors made to leave. When they opened the door, they saw the black figure standing 10 feet away in the drainage ditch behind the cabin.

Immediately startled (especially since this counselor had previously seen the figure), they turned back inside and the other person could see the fear and shock on their face, so much so that the argument ceased.

Thinking logically, they became sure that it was a third counselor who was interested in the conversation who was posted up as an eavesdropper. They called the suspect, but upon getting an answer, it was plainly obvious that nobody was talking behind the cabin.

Upon a second glance, the figure had dissipated by this time.

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New sightings have been reported in the 2025 year, but due to limitations on my ability to talk with the sources, these go unrecorded for now.

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